

10 THINGS PEOPLE DO IN A BLACKOUT THAT KILL THEM INDOORS

Every winter, the same ten mistakes turn up in the reports. Here they are, worst numbers first, with the fix for each.

THE THREE THAT POISON YOU

1 Charcoal

A grill or hibachi burned indoors. Glowing coals make carbon monoxide with no flame, smoke, or smell. It kills about 12 a year. FIX: charcoal never comes inside, and a closed garage counts as inside.

2 Heaters

Unvented propane or kerosene, door shut. In a government test 6 of 8 propane heaters failed, one at 2,124 parts per million, and the room ran low on oxygen first. FIX: only a heater with an oxygen depletion sensor, a window cracked, never overnight.

3 The car

Idling in the garage or a snowbank. A plugged tailpipe filled a cabin with a lethal dose in two and a half minutes. FIX: tailpipe clear, car outside, never in the garage even with the door up.

Carbon monoxide binds your blood 200 to 250 times tighter than oxygen. A twenty dollar battery alarm on every floor is the cheapest thing on this whole list.



Charcoal indoors: no flame, no smell, and the whole house asleep. A battery alarm is the backstop.



A buried tailpipe fills the cabin in two and a half minutes. Cracking a window only buys a few more.

THE TWO THAT BURN YOU

4 Candles

A candle by the bed is the most ordinary fire in America. Heat crosses a gap; a curtain only has to reach its ignition point. Fires that start while everyone sleeps are about three times as deadly. FIX: candle in a jar, on a bare surface, out before your eyes close. A battery lantern never sets the bed on fire.

5 Space heater

Shoved against the couch, a blanket over the grille. Space heaters are a small share of heating fires but most of the deaths. FIX: 3 feet of clear air on every side, hard floor, off when you sleep.

THE FIVE THAT FREEZE YOU, AND THE ONE THAT IS NOT A MISTAKE

COLD KILLS QUIETLY

No poison, no fire. These just lower your core until you stop, and the warning signs are easy to miss.

6 Drinking

The flush is the lie. Alcohol drops your blood sugar, and shivering runs on blood sugar, so the drink quietly switches off your furnace while it makes you feel warm. FIX: hot tea with sugar, not whiskey.

7 Wet clothes

You shovel, you sweat, you climb into bed in it. Water pulls heat out roughly 25 times faster than air. In a snow cave, stripping the wet layer rewarmed people in 12 minutes; wrapped up wet, it took 28. FIX: dry clothes on before the blankets go over.

8 Eating snow

Melting a couple of pounds of snow inside you costs close to 120 food calories, straight out of your core, and snow is mostly air. FIX: melt it first, then boil it if you can. Melting alone does not make bad water safe.

9 THE HOT BATH

Someone is shivering, confused, cold to the touch, so you run a hot bath. It can stop the heart. Cold blood is parked out in the arms and legs; hot water throws those vessels open and floods it back to a cold heart. Doctors call it afterdrop.

- ☐ Alert and only mildly cold: warm just the forearms and lower legs, up to the elbows and knees, in water at 108 to 113 Fahrenheit.
- ☐ Warm the middle slowly, with blankets and a warm drink.
- ☐ Confused, or shivering stopped while still cold, is a nine one one call, not a bath.

10 LEAVING THE OLDEST PERSON ALONE IN THE COLDEST ROOM

In the 2021 Texas freeze, 158 people died of hypothermia, and 107 of those were 60 or older. In an older body, shivering starts later and weaker and the blood vessels clamp down less, so the same cold room that leaves you stiff can leave your father dangerously cold, and confusion comes before he feels it. The first move on night one is not a heater. It is a headcount. The oldest person sleeps in the warmest room, with somebody else in it, and gets checked before dawn.

Watch the full video: youtube.com/@SketchySurvival101

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And the one that is not on this list, the generator, has its own video. Subscribe so the next blackout does not catch you flat footed.

Sketchy Survival 101. Physics first survival. Numbers here come straight from the video and its sources: the Consumer Product Safety Commission, the National Fire Protection Association, the Centers for Disease Control, the Wilderness Medical Society, and the Texas health department. If in doubt in a real emergency, call nine one one.